

A comparison of Nagios, Zenoss and Zabbix

Feature	Nagios	Zenoss	Zabbix
Basic features (CPU, disk, memory)	Yes	Yes	Yes
Auto discovery	Partial	Yes	Partial
Licence	Free	Free	Free
Inventory support	No	Yes	Yes
Plug-in support	Yes	Yes	Yes
Web dashboard	Good	Excellent	Excellent
Windows monitoring	Partial	Yes	Yes
SNMP trapping	Partial	Yes	Yes
Syslog monitoring	Partial	Yes	Yes
Trend analysis	Partial	Yes	Partial
Google Maps View	No	No	Yes
Graphical reports	No	Yes	Yes
User-friendly configuration	Yes	Partial	Partial
Performance and reliability	Medium	High	Low
Plug-in API support	Partial	Yes	Yes
Security monitoring	No	No	No

a highly flexible monitoring platform for mid scale and large scale infrastructures. It supersedes Nagios in a few cases, especially when it comes to alert management.

Zabbix: This is really an enterprise class open source tool. Written in C and PHP, it has very elaborate dashboards that provide admins a detailed drill down.

While it is tough to decide which tool is best for monitoring, here are a few guidelines. Administrators should first look at their infrastructure from the uptime perspective and decide what needs to be really monitored, rather than checking all that they can possibly monitor. This focused approach is important because it is easy to get distracted with multiple features available in each tool. Hence, focusing on the basic monitoring requirements mentioned earlier should be first on the agenda. As a second step, admins should look into the applications to be monitored and decide whether or not custom scripting needs to be done to achieve what they need from the monitoring standpoint. The third step should be to focus on reporting and trend analysis, because as infrastructure grows, it is essential to have a historic record of the problems in IT infrastructure.

The last but important step would be to see if security monitoring is a requirement in the given scenario. If yes, then it is crucial to decide the level of additional scripting and log generation that would be required. The generated log can

then be captured by a monitoring tool and report as a problem incidence via the trouble ticketing system.

Nagios, Zenoss and Zabbix are all industry grade, professional tools with large installation bases. It has been observed that Nagios and Zenoss perform very well on the Ubuntu platform, while Zabbix runs great on other distros. Zenoss is unique among the three tools compared, because it offers more features, interacts well with multiple databases and other tools, and also has proved itself to be a robust solution even for high performing, large scale IT infrastructures. Besides these three, there are tools such as Cacti, OpenNMS, Cricket, etc, which I leave readers to find more about on the Net. It is always better to compare an open source tool with a commercial one, and decide and choose the required features. 

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